

# POLITICAL SYSTEMS

NO TWO COUNTRIES have identical political systems, since over the years each country has evolved a form that suits its history, culture, people, and rulers. However, it is possible to group the political systems of the world into a few main categories. There can be variations within each category. Some countries have a system that is in transition from one category to another, such as Afghanistan, which is moving from theocracy to multi-party democracy, or Zimbabwe, which is being moved from democracy to dictatorship by its leader, Robert Mugabe.

Woman voting in elections in India – the world's most populous democracy.



## POLITICAL TERMS

**Alliance** A formal agreement between nations for economic, political, or military reasons.

**Apartheid** A policy of separating people by race.

**Capitalism** A system in which wealth and profit in the hands of a few people drives the country's economy.

**Communism** A system in which property and land are owned by the whole community and each person is paid according to their needs and abilities.

**Democracy** A system in which people vote for the government of their choice.

**Economy** The organization of a country's finances, exports, imports, industries, and services.

**Multiparty elections** More than one party running for election.

**Nationalized** Industries or services owned by the state.

**Privatization** State-owned organizations taken over by private companies.

**Republic** A state where people elect the head of state and the government.

**Socialism** A system in which the economy is controlled by the whole community.

**Trade union** An organized group of workers united to protect their rights and interests.

**West, the** Countries in Europe and North America with capitalist economies and democratic governments that share similar cultural values.

## MULTIPARTY DEMOCRACY

In a multiparty democracy, people are given a choice between several parties to elect. Because this allows different points of view to be expressed in public and opposition to form against the elected government, not every country can make a multiparty democracy work. Some countries claim to be multiparty democracies, but real power is actually held by the president.

### CONSTITUTIONAL MONARCHY

In a constitutional monarchy, the head of the ruling royal family is head of state and is succeeded by his or her closest relative in hereditary succession. Japan, for example, is a constitutional monarchy whose head of state is the emperor. The monarch has no real power, but acts as a figurehead for the country. This is in the hands of the democratically elected government, led by the prime minister, the ruler of the largest party in parliament. Over the years, many countries have evolved from absolute to constitutional monarchies.

### FEDERAL REPUBLIC

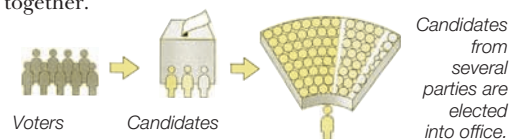
Some nations, including Germany, are federal republics, with each state in the republic having considerable power and electing its own prime minister. In Germany, the federal assembly acts as an umbrella over the states and elects a chancellor (prime minister) to rule the republic as a whole. The president is chosen by the states and assembly together.

Pro-democracy protesters are confronted by riot police in Indonesia.



### PRESIDENTIAL REPUBLIC

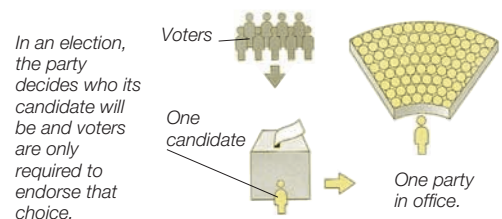
A presidential republic is a true democracy where voters choose both the head of state – the president – and elect representatives to the legislature. It is the most common form of government in the world. In countries such as the US and South Africa, the president is both the head of state and of government. In France and Russia, the president is elected head of state and chooses the prime minister to run the government, but retains considerable power in the running of the nation. In many countries, such as Ireland, India, and Israel, the president is a symbolic figurehead and real power is held by the prime minister and government.



## ONE-PARTY STATE

In a one-party state, only one political party is allowed to exist. All other parties are forbidden. All power in the state is held by the one party. The former communist states of eastern Europe and many of the African nations are now moving from being one-party states to establishing a multiparty democracy.

Soldiers on the streets in Indonesia



## THEOCRACY

In a theocracy, power is held by religious leaders who rule according to their scriptures. In Iran, the *mullahs* – Muslim scholars and priests – hold the real power, though the government is in non-religious hands. The Vatican

City, the world's smallest state, is a mixture of a theocracy and an elected monarchy. The head of state is the Pope, who is leader of the world's Roman Catholics. He is elected for life by cardinals, who are senior clergy.

## ONE-PARTY DOMINATED STATES

Some countries, such as Egypt and Tunisia, claim to be multiparty democracies, but are run by a single party that keeps a firm hold on power, often with the support of the army, as in Syria.